

HT AND HTOED: DRAFT GUIDING PRINCIPLES

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THE CHALLENGE

- The HTE project: 1965-present
 - Many editors, generally carried out under the leadership of two people (both now deceased)
 - Work was flexible and emergent and rules not often written down but practice-based
 - We're trying to reconstruct it from documents and from our own heads...
- Principles all emerged from practice
 - Not imposed a priori, but discovered through engagement with data
 - “We have thus tried as far as possible to allow the classification to emerge from the data rather than be imposed upon it” (Kay 1976)
 - Principal framework is structuralist semantics

THEORETICAL FOUNDATION: LEXICAL FIELD THEORY

- Based on structural semantics approach
 - Saussure's *valeur*: meaning exists only in relation to other meanings
 - von Humboldt: language as organic system of interrelated subsystems
- Key concept: The lexical field
 - “A system of sense-relations which... is nonetheless seen as having an identity of its own”
 - Example: “Religion” overlaps with “morality,” “myth,” “ritual observances”
 - Boundaries are “vague and difficult to define”
- No-one has ever satisfactorily answered the question of how to determine field boundaries
 - Core items vs peripheral items
 - The problem of arbitrary inclusion or exclusion

PRINCIPLE 1: FOLK TAXONOMY AND FUNCTIONAL CLASSIFICATION

- “*What’s it for?*” rather than “*What is it?*”
 - Based on “accidental rather than inherent properties”
 - Reflects human functional perspective, not philosophical taxonomy
- Example: Writing desk classification
 - NOT: *furniture and fittings > desk > writing desk*
 - BUT: *communication > writing > writing materials > writing desk*
- This creates classificatory tensions:
 - Where does “religious music” belong?
 - Solution: Split domains when necessary
 - Supernatural, occult → External World (explaining the world)
 - Organized religion → Social World (social construct)

PRINCIPLE 2: THE PRINCIPLE OF LEAST EXTENSION

- “Individual lexical items are classified according to the feature of least extension”
- Core idea: Place items in the *narrowest, most specific category* that fits
- Classic example: *lava* and *volcanic ash*
 - Said to be best classified with VOLCANO, not with STONE or DUST
 - Maintains semantic precision
- BUT: Real implementation reveals complexity
 - Actually ended up in *structure of earth > constituent materials*
 - Shows tension between principle and practical organization
- How to handle compounds?
 - *Sea salt* under SALT or SEA?
 - *Church bell* under BELL or CHURCH EQUIPMENT?

PRINCIPLE 3: CONCRETE TO ABSTRACT, GENERAL TO PARTICULAR

- Overall progression: External World → Mental World → Social World
- Reverses Roget's approach (which began with abstract relations)
- Rationale: Historical development of language
 - Concrete terms likely preceded abstract
 - Metaphors for mental concepts derive from physical world
- Within categories:
 - “Begin with the most general and familiar”
 - “Work through to the most specific and technical”
- BUT: Size can override this principle if it helps the user (“principle o”)
 - Example: Cricket acquired thousands of terms, elevated from subcategory to standalone category

CLASSIFICATION PROCESS: FROM THEORY TO PRACTICE

- No set rules: “Each section will be different from the last”
- Typical workflow:
 1. First sort: 5-7 broad groupings + residue (Chase)
 2. Second sort: Sub-classes by “diagnostic components” in definitions
 3. Continue until “suitable level of delicacy”
- Definition-based classification:
 - Look for recurring keywords
 - BUT: Similar meanings may have different surface definitions
 - Must consider full sense including quotation evidence

HT DRAFT CLASSIFICATION

DOCUMENT: CORE DEFINITIONS

- An initial attempt (Andrew, Fraser, Jane, Kate, Marc) at ordering some of our thoughts and discussions, based on excerpts from old HT documents and publications
- Central concept: Each category represents a semantic field with coherent meaning

NEW CATEGORIES: SORTING PROCESS

- *Initial sort*: Classifiers create broad conceptual categories, some slips remain unsorted
- *Second sort*: Establishes categories and subcategories, usually settled at this stage
- *Iterative process*: Further attempts may explore different division methods
- *Hierarchical development*:
 - Save results before next round
 - Sort within categories to create new hierarchy levels
 - Use OED definitions for guidance, focus on recurring keywords
 - Consult specialist dictionaries for technical terms
- *Completion*: Repeat until all material has systematic placement

CATEGORY HEADINGS: NAMING CONVENTIONS

- *Primary approach*: Use current term for the concept or semantic field from category contents
- *Alternative approach*: Express relationship to parent category (e.g. 'parts of')
- *Clarity considerations*: Longer headings permissible to avoid offensive or insensitive language
- *User experience*: Consider electronic search functionality
- *Breadcrumb principle*: Headings should read coherently up the hierarchy
- *Parts of speech consistency*: Adjective categories headed adjectivally, etc.
- *Word selection*: Choose prominent, current words; avoid obscure or confusing terms

ORDERING PRINCIPLES: STRUCTURAL GUIDELINES

- No universal rules: Each category requires individual consideration
- Coordinate relationship: Categories or subcategories at same level are equal
- Guiding principles:
 - Concrete to abstract (original Thesaurus principle)
 - General to particular (prioritised when conflicts with concrete-to-abstract)
 - Inherent arrangements: top-bottom, front-rear, size, location, importance
 - Parts or components before kinds or varieties
 - Polarity (occasionally applicable)
- Purpose: Aid user navigation, not indicate importance differences
- Category elevation: Subcategories promoted based on size, concept importance, consistency, or hierarchical requirements

ORDERING EXAMPLE (CHASE): BUILDING PARTS

- Problem: How to classify parts of complex structures?
 - Church buildings: larger, less familiar, more complex than houses
 - Functional classification fails (multi-purpose spaces)
 - No constant relationship between function and location
- Chase's 'locomotive' solution:
 - Order parts as encountered on a walk through the building
 - All parts accorded equivalent status, sub-parts subordinated appropriately
- Arbitrary (different routes possible)
- Difficulty integrating peripheral structures (triforium, chapter house)
- Better than another organization? Or just idiosyncratic?

WORD CATEGORISATION: CLASSIFICATION PRINCIPLES

- *Folk vs scientific taxonomy*: Prefer folk taxonomy where sensible
 - “What’s it for?” prioritised over “what is it?”
 - Exception: Very technical areas (plant and animal taxonomies) require specialist approaches
 - Folk classifications more comprehensible to most users
- *Duplication rules*:
 - Word forms within same category generally avoided (legitimate exceptions exist)
 - Sense duplication avoided but considered for user findability
 - Future development may include cross-references
- *Residual categories*: ‘Other types of’ for single-word categories when necessary
 - Avoid where possible (lack coherent concept)
 - But sometimes only practical solution for residual words

BOUNDARY DISPUTES

- Faith vs Supernatural phenomena:
 - Where to place witchcraft, magic, folk belief?
 - Initial instinct: All under Religion
 - Solution: Split into two widely separated categories
 - Supernatural, occult → External World (explaining phenomena)
 - Organized religion → Social World (institutional)
- Music genres and cultural categories:
 - Religious music: Music or Religion?
 - Jazz: Music or African American culture?
 - Solution: Primary classification by *function*, cross-references for *access*
- Decisions will be classificatory ideology

MODERN CHALLENGES: FROM PRINT TO DIGITAL

- Original constraints of print format:
 - Brief category headings
 - Rigid hierarchical display
 - No cross-references between distant categories
- Digital opportunities:
 - Longer, more sensitive category headings
 - Web-like linking structures, move beyond hierarchy
 - Multiple access points
- Current tensions:
 - Folk taxonomy vs scientific accuracy
 - Menstruation: originally “organs of excretion”
 - Now: “reproductive cycle”

CASE STUDY: SOCIAL MEDIA

- (We're going to discuss computing later, but these are notes from a presentation I gave a while ago as an example!)
- Immediate questions:
 - Under *Communication*? *Technology*? *Social Interaction*?
 - How to handle platform-specific vocabulary?
- Applying HT principles:
 1. *Folk taxonomy*: How do users conceptualize?
 2. *Least extension*: Platform-specific terms stay together?
 3. *Functional approach*: “What’s it for?”
 - Communication tool? Identity construction? Information sharing?
- Can multiple classification points work?
 - Primary under *Communication*, Technical terms under *Computing*, Social phenomena under *Social Behaviour*?

THE PARADOX OF SYSTEMATIC FLEXIBILITY

- Core tension: Systematic classification requires consistency
 - BUT: “No set rules to follow”
 - “One no sooner sets up a general principle than one is forced to revise it”
- The pragmatic solution:
 - Consistency within domains where possible
 - Accept different organizing principles across domains
 - Musical instruments: By playing method *and* construction?
- Some obvious points:
 - Language resists rigid systematization
 - Categories must “grow out of the relevant lexical field”
 - Only *users* really matter
 - Classification as interpretation, not description

OTHER ISSUES IN PRACTICE

- Close reading of definitions sometimes insufficient
 - Similar meanings may have divergent definition styles
- The importance of specialist knowledge
 - When to defer to scientific taxonomy
 - When folk categories better serve users
- The value of collaborative classification
 - A classification will always be idiosyncractic, but individual idiosyncrasies balanced by team review?

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Methodological questions:
 - How to formalize “suitable level of delicacy”?
 - When does a subcategory merit category status?
 - Can we quantify the “principle of least extension”?